vessels are made of cane reeds, woven together like a mat; which, when they put into port, they leave standing in the wind. In some of these vessels there will be employed a thousand men, six hundred of these sailors, and four hundred soldiers. Each of these larger ships is followed by three others, a middle sized, a third, and a fourth sized . . . They row in these ships with large oars, which may be compared to great masts, over some of which five and twenty men will be stationed, who work standing. The commander of each vessel is a great Emir. In the large ships, too, they sow garden herbs and ginger, which they cultivate in cisterns (made for that purpose) and placed on the sides of them. In these are also houses constructed of wood, in which the higher officers reside with their wives; but they do not hire out to merchants. Every vessel, therefore, is like an independent city. [1]

Ibn Battuta was assigned a cabin in a kakam, a smaller vessel, for his journey to China, but it was sunk in a storm and the rest of the fleet scattered. He finally managed to travel to China on a Chinese merchant ship from the port of Chittagong on the Bengal coast. Bengal at the time was ruled by the Bengal Sultanate, which had broken away from the Delhi Sultanate. Its capital was at Pandua.

In the Yuan dynastic history, the Ming Shi, it is recorded that during the years 1272 CE to 1296 CE , there were sixteen official missions to India, most of which visited Kollam. There are also references to eighteen Indian embassies to China, again mostly from the Malabar kingdoms. That these Indian maritime states enjoyed a high regard among the Mongols is apparent from the following reference in the Ming Shi:

. . . among all foreign nations across the seas, only Malabar and Kollam are capable of commanding (other) kingdoms. [2]

The Persian historian Wassaf (1265–1328 CE) who served under the Mongol Ilkhanid dynasty has written about the flourishing trade between China, Persia and the Malabar kingdoms:

The curiosities of Chin and Machin [this refers to the port city of Guangzhou], and the beautiful products of Hind and Sind, laden on large ships (which they call junks), [3] sailing like mountains with the wings of the winds on the surface of the water, are always arriving there. The wealth of the isles of the Persian Gulf in particular, and in part the beauty and adornments of other countries, from Irak (Iraq) and Khorasan, as far as Rum (Rome) and Europe, are derived from Malabar, which is so situated as to be the key of Hind. [4]

~